

Code of Conduct

Ronin Institute for Independent Scholarship 2.0 (RIIS 2.0)

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Interim Council

1. Purpose

This Code of Conduct provides guidelines for how Affiliates (Fellows and Associates) or staff of the Ronin Institute for Independent Scholarship 2.0 (RIIS 2.0) are expected to behave at all times. This Code of Conduct applies to all venues, including, but not limited to, RIIS 2.0 venues where Affiliates or staff may interact with other people. This Code of Conduct also applies to any time or place where we gather, including, but not limited to, places that are funded by or through, and/or represent RIIS 2.0 (including during travel for RIIS 2.0-related purposes). This Code of Conduct codifies the expectations of behavior of RIIS 2.0 to align with the values contained in the [Belonging Policy](#).

Our goal is to work together to help support a safe environment for everyone. As a community, we commit to enforcing this code as our Institute grows. This document is provided to Affiliates and employees upon joining RIIS 2.0 and is used as guidance to assess any behavioral issues that might come up. Importantly, this Code of Conduct helps to establish the culture that we want for our community.

2. Core Principles of Conduct

RIIS 2.0 aims for a flat, non-hierarchical structure, where every person here is, first and foremost, of equal standing. RIIS's Code of Conduct boils down to common sense and basic manners, but here are a few rules of thumb:

Be kind:

Be attentive to people's personal boundaries, and seek consent as much as possible. Be thoughtful when talking with or about each other; consider your word choices carefully. Remember that tone can be hard to judge online. Instead of labeling or classifying people, describe people's actions or behaviors. Recognize people's capacity to learn, grow, and change. Sometimes, we make mistakes. Let's assume that we each hope to do better.

Be open-minded:

There will doubtless be opportunities for spirited discussion, which will sometimes become heated. That's a good thing, so long as we value different perspectives with an open and listening mind. One must challenge one's own assumptions about oneself and others.

Practice fairness:

We should all be working to ensure that everyone has the opportunity to participate, share their ideas, and feel valued. Keep an eye out for opportunities to engage people who might feel less confident. Speak plainly, and avoid acronyms, jargon, slang, and idioms; some GIFs/emojis might not translate across cultures. Physical appearance, clothing, and demographic characteristics are unlikely to be germane to any of your conversations at RIIS 2.0. Offer clear and constructive comments that are helpful rather than critical. Be a humble expert and avoid lecturing. Be conscious of who is doing the heavy lifting in groups and activities (note-taking, scheduling, document creation, organizing). Aim to involve, rather than omit, as well as to flatten our power structures through sharing authority.

Be responsible:

We are all responsible for upholding the professional reputation and culture of RIIS 2.0 whenever and wherever we are associated with it. RIIS 2.0 funds and assets (including names, logos, email addresses, and websites) must be used responsibly, legally, and ethically.

Be proactive:

As a community, we are responsible for our institutional culture. Look out for opportunities where we can proactively shape our culture rather than letting events or our reactions shape our culture for us. If you experience or witness any harassment that is occurring and you feel safe doing so, RIIS 2.0 supports your efforts to call out harassment (describe it for what it is and ask the individual to stop) and support anyone who may be affected. You are also encouraged to reach out to any of the Code of Conduct contacts (below) to let someone know what happened.

Act In Good Faith and Assume Good Faith from Others:

Two of our core values at RIIS 2.0 are Truth and Empathy. To embody these, Affiliates should come prepared to engage with each other in good faith, presenting thoughts and ideas honestly and clearly, and listening to others with an open mind.

RIIS 2.0 Affiliates are a multifaceted group, representing different academic disciplines, career stages, cultures, and sets of obligations and constraints. We each have different career and life goals, as well as backgrounds and cultural

contexts.

Always take a breath and remind yourself that there is a person on the other side of the conversation. Work under the assumption that they, like you, are intelligent and well-intentioned. Remember that we're all in this together, and it is not a zero-sum game. Anything that helps one of our RIIS 2.0 Affiliates achieve their own goals helps the entire community. Our job is to provide mutual support in a way that will help each person benefit from RIIS 2.0 and achieve success on their own terms.

3. Community Conduct

Compliance with Law:

We comply with the law, including the laws governing nonprofit organizations and workplace behavior. We understand that, as a charity, we operate exclusively for public benefit and not for private purposes, and we are subject to stringent rules relating to conflicts of interest and political activities. We expect Affiliates and employees to understand the legal and regulatory requirements applicable to their role, including federal, state, and foreign laws, as well as the relevant regulatory schemes. All Affiliates and employees are also expected to act with integrity and to exercise good judgment and common sense in their efforts to comply with all applicable laws, rules, and regulations, and are encouraged to ask for advice when they are uncertain about them.

The organization shall comply with all applicable anti-discrimination laws, including Title VI, Title VII, and Title IX of the Civil Rights Act of 1964, the Age Discrimination in Employment Act of 1967 (ADEA), the Rehabilitation Act of 1973 (as amended), and the ADA Amendments Act of 2008 ADAAA. 42 U.S.C. ch 126 12101 et seq. that prohibit unfavorable treatment of any legally protected characteristics of individuals in its programs, activities, employment, and governance.

Harassment

RIIS 2.0 has a zero-tolerance policy for harassment, unfair treatment, other kinds of harassment (including, but not limited to, sexual harassment), or bullying of any kind. **“Harassment”** is defined as unwelcome conduct that deprives another individual of the opportunities and peaceful enjoyment they may take from participating in the community or an activity, when the perpetrator knows or ought to know that the conduct is unwelcome. Harassment can be a one-time severe event or repeated minor offenses.

We do not tolerate harassment in any form. Different types of harassing actions include, but are not limited to:

- Offensive verbal or written comments related to sex, sexual orientation, disability, physical appearance, body size, race, age, religion, etc
- Deliberate intimidation, stalking, following, bullying, or hostility
- Threats or acts of violence
- Unauthorized photography or recording, including making public recordings or screenshots of online discussions conducted through RIIS 2.0 platforms (e.g., Slack, Discord, Zoom) without permission of the participants.
- Sustained disruption of events or discussions
- Sexual advances or suggestive behavior/language
- Microaggressions, which are everyday verbal, nonverbal, and environmental slights, snubs, or insults that communicate hostile, derogatory, or negative messages and serve to exclude others
- Retaliation against anyone who reports a potential Code of Conduct violation
- Advocating for or encouraging any of the above behaviors

Other Issues:

Code of Conduct violations also include:

- Deliberate misrepresentation of research or scholarship
- Violation of confidentiality agreements or privacy expectations (see above)

Affiliates and employees are expected to comply with all applicable policies of RIIS 2.0, including any related to non-discrimination and conflicts of interest.

A RIIS 2.0 Affiliate who is asked by any person to stop behaviors that breach the Code of Conduct is expected to cease those behaviors immediately. All breaches of the Code of Conduct are taken seriously, and RIIS 2.0 will take action as needed.

4. Report concerns

If you are being harassed, intimidated, or have any other concerns, please follow our [Conflict Resolution Policy](#) immediately. If you are unsure whether the incident is a violation or whether the space where it happened is covered by this Code of Conduct, we still encourage you to report it. We pledge to listen and follow this policy to help Affiliates feel safe and comfortable at RIIS 2.0.

All reports will be kept confidential. Any conflicts of interest will be managed to ensure that your concern is addressed fairly. RIIS 2.0 does not tolerate retaliation against or the victimization of any RIIS 2.0 Affiliate who raises concerns or questions regarding a potential violation of the Code of Conduct.

5. Council approval

Signed: 

Rami Saydjari, Secretary
Ronin Institute for Independent Scholarship 2.0
Date: 2025-09-04

Document history

- Created April 13, 2025, by Rami Saydjari
- May 23, 2025: Incorporated revisions from Elena Fujiwara, Arika Virapongse, Carolyn Sealfon, Alex Lancaster, and Ruth Duerr
- May 28, 2025: Revised by Arika Virapongse, Jovita De Loatch, Rami Saydjari, Alex Lancaster, Keith Tse, Herbert J. Bernstein (Affiliation Working Group) (Version 1.0)
- September 3, 2025: Draft revised by Interim Council following pro-bono legal review (Version 1.1)